







EMBODYING HER VOICE The young Lata (top, right) and clockwise, her early screen personas: Meena Kumari, Nutan, Nimmi and Madhubala

bore a kinship to that great genepool of artistes from the Konkan coast: Kesarbai, Mogubai, and her daughter Kishori Amonkar (who apparently could not much stand Lata's popularity). And that bit of tutelage under Ustad Aman Ali Khan, the Bhendi Bazaar gharana maestro, filled her out.

There's a 1950 video of her singing Malkauns where you see a what-if of music history: she's a white finch in flight, tracing arcs in time, borne aloft as if by air, the high notes her natural habitat, adding daubs of filigree that never disturb the raag's solemnity. No wonder Ustad Bade Ghulam Ali Khan paid her that oft-reported compliment in mock-exasperation: "*Kambakht, kabhi besura nahin hoti.*" With her filament-like voice, she was also blessed that rare gift: perfect pitch.

But she was fated for another path, and it's here that the perfection spills over into other domains. If Lata's was a disembodied voice that rang out across all spaces—political boundaries no bar—it was also part of a compound artefact. Fundamentally, it was a *film* song, it had lyrics, and these were lip-synced by real women in a visualised story. Thus, one of its primary functions was to body forth a *kind* of woman, a specific feminine persona that came to fill Indian cinema. What we remember as a Lata song is also a village belle pining for that itinerant stranger to whom she has lost her heart: a Nimmi in sublime pain, an ethereal Madhubala, a Meena Kumari from before time wrought lines of fatigue on her, a Nutan gambolling across open fields, a Mala Sinha wistfully watching the rain—and years later, a Suchitra Sen in spinster's white, mirroring Lata's, singing of the unfulfilled, purposeless drift of life. Her musical persona was mapped onto those women. More often than not, they were waif-like ingenues, vulnerable, caught in aspects of virginal innocence. The industry cottoned on to this fast, bringing about that division of labour with Asha, on whom it fell to emote anything that was sexually less timid. As for Lata, even her courtesans were, ultimately, pure and sacralised: witness the duet in *Mughal-e-Azam*, where the pristine Madhubala is set off against a wily rival who is given voice to by the salty Shamshad Begum.

Contrapuntal notes come in when you consider the person, of course—the Peddar Road flyover affair, her fondness for the Thackerays, the much-talked-about 'Mangeshkar monopoly'. But those are extra-musical elements. Those who say she never let anyone grow in her shadow bark up the wrong tree. Her 'victims' were not the Suman Kalyanpurs and Sulakshana Pandits: they were doppelgangers, often indistinguishable from her. It's what was radically *different* that suffered.

The thing with perfection is that it abolishes anything tainted by imperfection according to its norms, anything with angularities, anything flesh and blood. What Lata's overarching presence wrought was another kind of monopoly: a monocrop actually, one that colonised India's infinitely polyphonic universe. What evacuated the stage was the timbral richness of the thumri voice, the tawaif's song of experience, the throaty folk chanteuse, the saltiness of the earth. That wasn't her fault, that's how we liked our illusions in those days: censored, disinfected. That's the real monopoly we struggle with. So, we live with Lata.

A phoneticist friend once told me that the sounds we produce never really die, they keep bouncing around the walls of the universe forever. You could believe that of the early Lata: blemish-free, weightless, its being that of the morning dew, like the purest air had been condensed and turned into an orb of light—an adularescent pebble that, if you flung it across a lake's surface, might bounce off into infinity.

—Sunil Menon